

Logitech's face tracking was the best; the QuickCam Sphere MP even uses a motorised swivel (pan and tilt, which can be controlled using the software). Logitech's RightLight and Creative's Live View Auto Tuning technologies both support real-time (dynamically-adjusting) exposure control for their webcams. The QuickCam Sphere MP supports single-click 2304 x 1728 panorama shots.

Accessories

The QuickCam software bundle with the QuickCam Sphere MP allows for software control of the motorised swivel. The Advance Video FX functionality in the Creative's Photo Manager software, and Logitech's Video Effects, allow using avatars during Web chats. Microsoft's Kiwe9 Theme pack needs to be downloaded and is a limited trial.

The QuickCam Notebook Pro has a 153 cm earphone and microphone combo—great for laptops. It has a 12-inch Desktop stand, too. The Logitech QuickCam Sphere MP is provided with a 9-inch extender to raise its height—a very effective add-on for a security camera.

Aesthetics And Build Quality

The Creative Live! Cam Optia is the coolest-looking webcam we received. The blue LED lights up while in use. The Logitechs are not the best-looking ones here; the Microsoft scores better. Even in the case of notebook cameras, it's the same: the Microsoft NX-6000 looks better than the QuickCam Notebook Pro. Logitech, however, leads in build quality. The Logitech webcams are much more stable than the others, with their slightly heavier base. The QuickCam Notebook Pro's Desktop stand and the QuickCam Sphere MP's heavy base prevent accidental toppling.

Performance

In Daylight

The use of good-quality CMOS sensors in this category is evident. The Creative Live! Cam Optia is unmatched in terms of sharpness, with excellent natural colour tone reproduction. The Microsoft VX-6000 excels in reproducing the accurate amount of brightness along with good contrast ratio and sharpness.

In Fluorescent Light

The Creative Live! Cam Optia remained unbeaten in terms of sharpness and colour reproduction. The QuickCam Pro 5000's performance was below par. The colour reproduction of the Microsoft VX-6000 was off the mark. The Creative Live! Cam Optia's matchless image quality in fluorescent lighting conditions makes it the most



Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000

Convergence of performance and value

practical webcam we reviewed—most users typically use webcams in low-light and fluorescent lighting conditions.

Rounding It Up

In the Vanilla Webcams category (up to Rs 800), most have average build. In terms of price as well as performance, Tech-Com bags both the Gold and the Silver. The Tech-Com SSD-644K, despite its poor build quality, takes the *Digit Best Buy Gold* on the basis of its performance in our image quality tests. The snap switch on the SSD-644K, along with the power switch for the night vision LEDs, boost its score. The runner-up—the SSD-645K—is the *Digit Best Buy Silver*, with performance way better than the others in fluorescent lighting, along with good performance in daylight conditions. Crafted in alloy with a plastic base, the SSD-645K promises to be long-term companion.

In the second category (Mid-range Webcams, Rs 801 to 1,700), the Zebronic 1300 WC wins the *Digit Best Buy Gold*. It has the right blend of performance and features. Remember, it uses a dual lens, one for short distances and other for long ranges. The snapshot button on the USB cable is an innovative feature that will be useful for many; it reduces the possibility of the webcam shaking while taking a snap. The Logitech QuickCam Messenger takes the Silver medallion on the basis of better colour reproduction in fluorescent lighting than the Zebronic 1300 WC.

Under Performance Webcams, Rs 1,701 to 3,000, the Logitech QuickCam IM is the best—*Digit Best Buy Gold*. The Genius Look313 Media is a feature-rich product that manages to come in a close second, losing out on the price front to the QuickCam IM.

In The Niche Category (above Rs 3,000), the Creative Live! Cam Optia was the best-looking, and it didn't disappoint on the performance front either. The Creative Optia takes the *Digit Best Buy Gold* on the basis of performance. The Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000 is an average performer compared to the Optia, but scores well on the price front—taking the *Digit Best Buy Silver*.

Webcams aren't overly expensive, and are cheaper than ever before. Now you even know what you should be buying... go ahead, take the plunge! You never know how much fun you might have with your webcam—and it's not just "fun": Web chats become so much more personal with a camera on.

It's also nice to have a webcam on top of your monitor. Even if you don't use it. ☒

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